Qualitative Psychology

ISSN: 2326-3601

2026, Vol. 13, No. 1, 1–5
https://doi.org/10.1037/qup0000353

EDITORIAL

A Consideration of the Ethics and Methodological Integrity of Generative Artificial Intelligence in Qualitative Research: Guidelines for *Qualitative Psychology*

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As generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools have become more widely available, qualitative researchers are questioning the potential for its use within qualitative research studies. This editorial presents the policy that the associate editors, incoming editor, and I have developed at *Qualitative Psychology* around AI use in qualitative analysis. This policy complements the American Psychological Association AI policy but is specifically focused on the use of AI within qualitative research. It provides a summary of major concerns that have been expressed in the field, including ethical, scientific, methodological integrity, social justice, and environmental concerns. This policy describes why we prohibit the use of AI in peer reviews of articles as well as in the processes of conducting literature reviews, describing methods, collecting and analyzing data, extracting data from articles, drafting descriptions of analyses and findings, interpreting analyses, or as a sole or primary and/or unchecked source for identifying citations and references. It provides guidance for the use of AI in translation and for the citation of AI-developed content. Our policy will continue to be reviewed and updated as the field evolves.

Keywords: artificial intelligence, qualitative research, qualitative methods, policy

At the American Psychological Association convention last summer, I was presenting with Nick Pierorazio about qualitative and integrative meta-analytic methods, and we were approached by a representative from a tech company that was developing generative artificial intelligence (AI)-driven software for qualitative analysis. At that time the associate and incoming editors and I were in the process of developing an AI policy for *Qualitative Psychology (QP)*, but I had only recently begun receiving submissions in which authors had used AI in their development (or in which this was reported). I remember wondering to Nick that perhaps this would not be a trend that would catch on. Why would someone want to relinquish to a machine the joy and creativity inherent in the process of discovery? Wasn't the process of expanding your perspective through immersion in the data the best part of qualitative analysis? Half a year later, I find that I receive almost weekly questions about the use of AI and have to make AI-related decisions about submissions. As a result, it has seemed urgent that we develop a policy on AI for our journal—both for the sake of transparency in our process and to communicate our recommendations to other journals that publish qualitative research.

We have not been alone in our concerns. The American Psychological Association has developed an AI policy that is focused on how to cite AI contributions and where to do so within articles (https://www.APA.org/pubs/journals/resources/publishing-tips/policy-generative-ai). In this policy, they prohibit the use of AI within the peer review process to protect both the integrity of the review

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The author thanks Roberto Abreu, Leeat Granek, Elena Kim, Linda McMullen, and Gabriel Velez for sharing their comments and thoughts in the development of the author's policy.

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process and the confidentiality of authors' work. They also have added a question to their article submission portal that asks about AI use, so editors can be informed about its use in article being reviewed. At the same time, they are continue to develop their AI policy and have not yet addressed the use of AI in qualitative research. Because of the rapidity of the development and use of AI and the level of questions on this topic, we are publicizing our journal policy, even though differences exist in the *QP* and APA policy. These differences may be due to the APA policy having a broad focus while the *QP* policy is meant to address best practices for qualitative research.

In addition to the policies by APA and *QP*, a group of 416 experienced qualitative researchers have written a strong position article against the use of AI in reflexive qualitative research (Jowsey et al., 2025). The central reasons that they considered in their rejection of AI included these programs' inability to engage in meaning-making, the idea that qualitative research should remain a human practice, and the many harms of AI corporations to the environment and their disproportionate effects in the Global South. This open letter made clear the high level of concern that qualitative researchers, many leaders in the field, have about the use of AI in qualitative research.

As we put forward a policy for *QP*, we make clear the scope of the research that we publish because it is for this research that our policy is intended (for more details, see Levitt, 2024). We have a long history of publishing methodological writings as well as research in which researchers engage in interpretive and inductive processes, iteratively moving between consultations of their data and internal reflections to shape insightful understandings (e.g., Rennie, 2012). We feature research in which investigators think deeply about their research design, considering its methodological integrity in relation to the questions, participants, and philosophical aims in use (see Levitt et al., 2017). *QP* has long published critical qualitative research and values studies that examine phenomena in terms of both their context and power dynamics such as stigma, colonialism, class, and systemic and institutionalized processes. Our authors tend to overtly consider not only their personal experiences related to their inquiry (or the situation or primary authors in meta-analyses) but their positionality and the limits that both can create in their analytical process. They are asked to report reflexive considerations on how they managed their expectations (e.g., heightening self-awareness, seeking consensus strategically, using participatory methods). Our special sections often advance contemporary methodological reformulations of concepts so they become coherent with the logic of qualitative inquiry (e.g., on reflexivity, Finlay, 2017 and Granek, 2017; on generalization, Osbeck & Antczak, 2021; on intersubjective agreement and causality, Levitt, 2021; on antiracist methods, Abreu & Wiliams, 2025). We do not, however, publish research in which researchers use quantitative methods to examine qualitative variables or in which they conduct deductive analyses that compare or identify the frequency of codes that were developed outside of the research process. Although the many questions and submissions we have received so far have helped us to flesh out the policy, we are aware that there are likely issues that we have not yet encountered and remain unaddressed. Also, the field is changing rapidly. As a result, we recognize that our editors may need to make decisions that seem to fit new situations that evolve, and we are committed to continuing to reconsider and update the policy as the field develops.

Guidance on the Use of AI for *QP* Submissions

This guidance reflects on the use of generative AI in the processes of qualitative research and manuscript development for authors submitting to *QP*. It is important to us that readers continue to trust the research that we publish and that there is transparency about the kind of qualitative research that we view as high quality, as ethical, and as having scientific and methodological integrity. The editorial board expects authors to adhere to this guidance when submitting manuscripts to our journal.

Concerns About the Use of AI in Qualitative Research

The following are central concerns about the use of generative AI methods within the process of qualitative research:

1. *Scientific and methodological integrity concerns regarding fabrication:* AI has been known to fabricate information, findings, and citations, with the proportions of misinformation appearing to be escalating over time (Metz & Weise, 2025). For instance, a recent study examined eight AI programs on their data extraction of over

300,000 data points from 22 systematic review databases, finding excellence in accuracy within only 12% of variables and at least some unacceptable metrics within 66% of variables (Jansen et al., 2025). Another assessment of fabrications in a large set of large language models found that the best 25 still had error rates that ranged between 3.3 and 10.9%, with some popularly used models not making the list (e.g., Gemini-3-pro had a 13.6% rate; Awadallah & Mendelevitch, 2025). This means that information gathered by AI is not reliable and, when used in scientific studies, needs to be checked for accuracy via human analysis.

2. *Scientific and methodological integrity concerns regarding bias and manipulation:* AI can be influenced by public stereotypes and prejudices in its training materials, by the values and agenda of its creators, as well as by the types of training material that it has encountered; it appears that AI may be deliberately adjusted to reflect certain perspectives or to communicate misinformation for political or others ends (Jones, 2025; Thompson et al., 2025).
3. *Scientific and methodological integrity concerns regarding lack of morality and reflexivity:* Moral, ethical, critical, and reflexive capacities are necessary to perform strong qualitative research (Braun & Clarke, 2022; Levitt et al., 2021; Shaw et al., 2020), but these features are lacking in AI. AI is unable to examine its positionality critically or seek out information that would balance biases or gaps in its training material.
4. *Scientific integrity and methodological concerns regarding artificial data drift:* Because AI can generate information faster than people, AI in the future may be trained dominantly on AI-produced or synthetic data. This issue can lead to models collapsing and to AI outputs increasingly misrepresenting real data distributions (Shumailov et al., 2024).
5. *Ethical concerns regarding inadequate sourcing and referencing:* There are ethical concerns about AI because the basis for information it produces is rarely fully documented, and authors or artists often do not give consent for their work to be used as training material (Ortutay, 2025). This inadequate sourcing can make it difficult for authors to adhere to scientific ethics of citation.
6. *Ethical concerns regarding appropriation:* Work that is submitted into an AI program may be incorporated into the data that feed the AI program without seeking the authors' consent (Andreotta et al., 2022). These programs may store and use the ideas and works of authors and may not support users to know of or cite those contributions in a way that accords with scientific ethics.
7. *Environmental concerns:* Concerns about the environmental impact of AI are sharply growing (Yu et al., 2024). Research suggests that many of the environmental costs are still not well known, including its impact on not only electricity demanded but the consumption of fresh water and rare metals (Dungo et al., 2025). Qualitative researchers from across the globe have expressed concern about exploitative and extractive impacts of AI and cautioned against its use (Jowsey et al., 2025).
8. *Social justice concerns:* These environmental concerns appear to be disproportionately impacting low-income neighborhoods and communities that are on rural or indigenous lands. A recent review of the research on the impact of AI stresses the necessity of not only considering its efficiency gains but also "hidden or temporally deferred costs that accumulate and—notably—the distributional consequences that determine who reaps the benefits and who inherits the burdens" (Ojong, 2025, p. 8305).

Guidance for the Use of AI and Accepted Practices in *QP*

For these ethical, environmental, and research integrity reasons, *QP* encourages authors to avoid using AI in developing scientific articles. The preceding concerns make clear why the fidelity of AI outputs appears questionable at this point. They require caution about the capacity of AI programs to reflect human experience and social practices in an ethical, socially just, and environmentally just manner.

In keeping with APA policy, *QP* prohibits reviewers from entering any part of a manuscript into AI or from using AI in the making of any part of the guidance or recommendations that they provide when reviewing a manuscript. We caution researchers to take care that confidential information (e.g., from clinical or research contexts), or data owned by someone else, is not shared with AI programs that store or appropriate their data. Before entering information into AI programs, researchers should know whether the programs are compliant with privacy acts and confidentiality laws in their countries (e.g., HIPAA). Data residency requirements (where data is stored), the availability of audit logs, the level of reproducibility in findings, and evidence on the proportion of fabrications may be beneficial information for researchers to learn as well (Silber, 2026).

We encourage researchers to consider the costs of using AI. Its use can limit the engagement of investigators which makes qualitative research insightful, ethical, responsive to the complexity of human experiences, and rewarding. In response to environmental concerns, *QP* editors encourage researchers to seek options for word selection or sentence-level editing that have lower environmental costs and have fewer ethical or data integrity concerns (e.g., using the Thesaurus option in Word or a less environmentally impactful AI program).

To be specific, *QP* does not publish articles in which AI was used:

- To conduct literature reviews
- To draft text describing research design and methods
- To extract, collect, and/or analyze data or other information
- To draft descriptions of analyses and findings
- To interpret analyses or connect findings to the literature
- As a sole, primary, and/or as an unchecked source for identifying references and citations

If AI was used in an article, a detailed statement making clear that it was not used for these activities listed above and specifying how it was used is required.

QP is aware of the advantages that AI can have for authors who are non-English speakers and who may face difficulty in publishing in English-language journals. If AI is used in translation, please append a copy of the manuscript in the original language in the online supplementary material. Once the article is accepted, please head a resubmitted version with a description of changes that were made in the review process and instructions for readers to cite the published version of the article. The availability of this document can increase the accessibility of that work, especially in the country where the research was conducted. Also, in line with *QP*'s expectations for such use of AI for translation, please indicate in the AI statement that a human who is fluent in both the original language and English has reviewed and assessed the translation quality, correcting any errors.

Like traditional sources, AI-generated works and information must be cited in an article, when they are used as a source that is quoted, paraphrased, or otherwise incorporated. Any use of AI requires that the author(s) include the full output of the AI in supplemental material, other than its use for word selection and sentence-level editing. Please refer to the page below for details on the APA AI policy as well, to which our journal also abides. Guidance is available at the link below on where within an article, information on AI use should be cited, although please keep in mind that we have further restrictions on AI use than APA has listed at this point because of our journal's specific focus on qualitative research (https://www.APA.org/pubs/journals/resources/publishing-tips/policy-generative-ai).

Please note that AI cannot be an author or coauthor on an article because it cannot be responsible for ensuring the accuracy and originality of the work. Human authors hold this responsibility and need to ensure that there is no plagiarism or errors in their research, text, images, citations, or references.

In the spirit of promoting transparency and openness, we encourage reaching out to the editor if author(s) have questions or require clarification. Articles that have been found to use AI in contravention of this statement may have their acceptances revoked. This position reflects our commitment to research ethics based in honoring the confidentiality, experiences, and humanity of our participants and careful, in-depth analysis and interpretation of data.

We expect that this guidance will need to be updated periodically as information on AI use and practices in the field develop. Editors may consider individual submissions in light of changing practices and information.

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Received December 6, 2025
Accepted December 6, 2025 ■